Getting Out of Your Own Way

By Linda Pastan, Danna Faulds, and Thich Nhat Hahn.

The Obligation to Be Happy by Linda Pastan, *Self-Observation Without Judgement* by Danna Faulds, *Please Call Me By My True Name* by Thich Nhat Hahn (COLOR-CODED in splicing of poems)

Happiness. I try to hoist it
on my narrow shoulders again—

It is more onerous
than the rites of beauty
or housework, harder than love.
But you expect it of me casually,
the way you expect the sun
to come up, not in spite of rain
or clouds but because of them.

Release the harsh and pointed inner
voice. it's just a throwback to the past,
and holds no truth about this moment.

Let go of self-judgment, the old,

4NG Fanatics

learned ways of beating yourself up
for each imagined inadequacy.

Do not say that I will depart tomorrow
because even today I still arrive

INTRODUCTION

From the moment we're born until the day we die, we are told what to do and how to act. We have this idea that people have expectations for us and we need to meet their standards. And that should be good enough. However, I do not strive for a "perfect" life, but for a better tomorrow. No one should belittle you; in turn, you shouldn't belittle yourself.

In the following program, through the poems The Obligation to Be Happy by Linda Pastan, Please Call Me by My True Name by Thich Nhat Hahn, and Self-Observation Without Judgment by Danna Faulds, we see the opportunity to give yourself room for change, mistakes, and success.

A program: Getting Out of Your Own Way - because we should all allow ourselves to grow.

Do not say that I will depart tomorrow
because even today I still arrive
Look deeply: I arrive in every second
to be a bud on a spring branch
to be a tiny bird, with wings still so fragile
learning to sing in my new nest

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

to be a caterpillar in the heart of flower
to be a jewel hiding itself in stone

I still arrive, in order to laugh and to cry,
in order to fear and to hope,
the rhythm of my heart is the birth and death of
all that are alive.

Allow the dialogue within the mind
to grow friendlier, and quiet. Shift
out of inner criticism and life
suddenly looks very different.

I can say this only because I make
the choice a hundred times a day to release the
voice that refuses to
acknowledge the real me.

Do not say that I will depart tomorrow
because even today I still arrive

And so I smile, as if my own fidelity
to sadness were a hidden vice—
that downward tug on my mouth,
my old suspicion that health
and love are brief irrelevancies,
no more than laughter in the warm dark

4NG Fanatics

strangled at dawn.

I am the mayfly metamorphosing on the surface of
the river,
and I am the bird which, when spring comes, arrives
in time to eat the mayfly.
I am the frog swimming happily in the clear water
of the pond,
and I am also the grass-snake who,
approaching in silence, feeds itself on the frog.
I am the child in Uganda, all skin and bones,
my legs as thin as bamboo sticks,
and I am the arms merchant selling deadly weapons
to Uganda.
I am the 12-year-old girl, refugee on a small boat,
who throws herself into the ocean after being
raped by a sea pirate,
and I am the pirate, my heart not yet capable of
seeing and loving
I am a member of the politburo, with plenty of
power in my hands,
and I am the man who has to pay his "debt of blood"
to my people,
dying slowly in a forced labour camp.

Do not say that I will depart tomorrow
because even today I still arrive

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

What's needed here isn't more prodding toward
perfection, but
intimacy - seeing clearly, and
embracing what I see.
Love, not judgment, sows the
seeds of tranquility and change.

My joy is like spring, so warm it makes flowers
bloom in all walks of life.
My pain is like a river of tears, so full it fills up the
four oceans.
Please call me by my true names,
so I can hear all my cries and my laughs at once,
so I can see that my joy and pain are one.
Please call me by my true names,
so I can wake up,
and so the door of my heart can be left open,
the door of compassion.

Happiness. I try to hoist it
on my narrow shoulders again—
a knapsack heavy with gold coins.
I stumble around the house,
bump into things.
Only Midas himself
would understand.

Do not say that I will depart tomorrow

4NG Fanatics

because even today I still arrive.

SOURCE INFORMATION

The Obligation to Be Happy by Linda Pastan
Author: Linda Pastan
Book: Carnival Evening: New and Selected Poems 1968-1998
ISBN: 978-0393046311
Publisher: W. W. Norton and Company Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 1998

Self-Observation Without Judgement by Danna Faulds
Author: Danna Faulds
Book: One Soul: More Poems From the Heart of Yoga
ISBN: 978-0974410616
Publisher: Peaceable Kingdom Books
Date (Month/Year): October 2003

Please Call Me By My True Name by Thich Nhat Hahn
Author: Thich Nhat Hahn
Book: Call Me By My True Names: The Collected Poems of Thich Nhat Hahn
ISBN: 978-1888375169
Publisher: Parallax Press
Date (Month/Year): 1999

Cutting compliments of
Heather Whitney, Norfolk Public Schools, NE

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY